

Chasing a podium, one sport at a time

Disillusioned but unwilling to stop, Tariyal moved to Kurash for the 2023 Asian Games, only to lose in the first round and injure her knee. Still not done, she switched to fighting Jiu-Jitsu, winning nationals and then a world title in Greece.

Success brought its own frustration. Sponsors, she found, were reluctant to back an athlete past 30. Largely self-funded through her career, she has appeared on reality shows including Roadies and India's Ultimate Warrior to raise her profile and cover costs. "Sport by itself doesn't pay my bills," she says. Her husband knows this well too. "At one of her first national judo competitions, Suchika had injured her hand and barely had enough money to travel. She didn't have 50 rupees. She went on a train without a ticket. Her mindset has always been *bas pahunch jaun* (just let me get there)," Hooda says.

That same need to earn pulled her towards MMA, via an offer to fight for BRAVE Combat Federation after her Jiu-Jitsu world title. Lacking a striking background, she was persuaded to take the leap by UFC fighter Puja Tomar. She built a 2-1 professional record before the Asian Games opportunity arose. "Standing on the podium at a multi-event Games has always been the dream," she says.

Qualification required top-eight finishes at Asian level, sending her to two separate Asian Championships, in China and Tashkent, where she won bronze both times while still adjusting to the format. Amateur MMA differs sharply from the professional game: fights happen on a mat rather than in a cage, elbow strikes to the head and submissions such as heel hooks are banned, grounded fighters get only 20 seconds to advance position before being stood back up, and weigh-ins happen on fight day itself.

That 20-second limit cuts

against her judo instincts, honed around throwing an opponent and then working patiently towards dominance. "At the end of the day it's fighting. I know I can fight," she says.

Not everyone understands the choice to keep going. "People wonder why I'm 36 and still fighting. My husband supports me. He tells me I can stop when I want," she says.

Tariyal enters the Aichi-Nagoya Games as a medal contender on the strength of her recent results, but insists the medal isn't the whole point. "A lot of people get one chance in one sport to stand on the podium for the country. I'm getting one more. I don't think I can stop," she says.



Pics: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

TOTAL MEDALS AT STAKE

24